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CENTERPIECE

New Charles elementary school set to open

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Diasia Fisher, a second grade teacher at Thornton Elementary, organizes supplies for her classroom.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News



Anticipation and excitement was palpable in the halls and classrooms of Charles County's newest elementary school earlier this week as teachers and staff prepared for students.

Next Monday, Aug. 25, the anticipation should ease once the doors are opened for students at the new Margaret Jamieson Thornton Elementary School along with all of the other Charles public schools.

Staff at Thornton Elementary this week prepared to open its doors for 661 students for the first time next Monday — St. Mary's public schools opened on Wednesday, Aug. 20, and Calvert public schools were set to start next Tuesday, Aug. 26.

Thornton teachers, administrators and others went through the phases of the school day from where buses will park to what the cafeteria will be like, Principal Brian King said Wednesday morning.

“For a really long time, this has been a really nice building,” King said, referring to the lengthy construction of the new White Plains school. “Then the final ingredient to truly being the school is when the students come on Monday.”

King started his career in Charles County. He taught and was principal at Barnhart Elementary School and worked at Theodore G. Davis and Benjamin Stoddart middle schools before becoming principal at the school system's 23rd elementary school this year.

The school is named after Margaret Jamieson Thornton, an educator within Charles public schools, who became one of the system's first kindergarten teachers.

The purpose of a public school is education and student achievement, King said. The school is focused on providing education for students, but also building a sense of community.

“There's a saying that, ‘The school is the biggest house in the neighborhood,’” King said. “It means we need to be a place [where] all students feel welcome, feel seen [and] feel valued.”

As the Thornton Explorers, the school has five “explorers” as the mascots to make it more relatable and more academic focused, King said. The explorers are an athlete, archaeologist, artist, astronaut and doctor.

“They can see themselves, not only now, but what their ambitions might be,” King said.

Staff will be in the main lobby on the first day of school to help students to their classrooms, King said. The hallways are color coordinated. For instance, the teal hallway is for pre-K to first grade while the purple hallway is for fifth grade. Each hallway has a collaborative space for group work.

On the first day of school students will play “Who Am I?” to learn what students did over the summer, Carolyn Wooden, the technology facilitator at Thornton, said.

“I try to make a connection with the students,” Wooden said. “I want them to feel like this is a sense of family.”

Students from Billingsley, Arthur Middleton and Mary H. Matula elementary schools were rezoned to attend Thornton Elementary School. The school is located off St. Charles Parkway in White Plains at 5860 St. David Drive, within the new Highlands neighborhood development.

“I want them to be excited about coming here,” Erica Pickeral, a science teacher, said.

The science lab is upstairs and decorated with bright posters of scientists and positive messages.

Students will participate in “me-stew,” Pickeral said. They share small bits of information in a pot, like stew. One of the first activities students will do in the science lab is building the largest tower with spaghetti or index cards.

“I’m hoping that what students quickly get most excited about is how they feel as they’re walking the building,” King said. “And how they sense that every adult that they see throughout the building is there to support them.”

Charles public schools anticipates 28,000 students this school year. Updates and announcements for this year can be found at www.ccboe.com/quick-links/back-to-school-2025-26.

Device policyFor the 2025-2025 school year, Charles public schools updated student laptop allocations:

- Pre-K and kindergarten will continue using the shared iPad model
- Grades 1-2: devices will be shared at a 2:1 student-to-device ration and remain at school
- Grades 3-5: each student will have a dedicated device for in-school use only
- Grades 6-8: devices will be available in shared carts for classroom use. Students can check out a device upon request for home use, as needed
- Grades 9-12: students will receive a one-to-one take home device. Personal devices, excluding smart/cell phones, are allowed. A school-issued device is required for state testing. Any high school student choosing to bring their own device to school must follow the guidelines in the 2025-26 Code of Student Conduct

School mealsStudents can select from several breakfast and lunch menu items. Menus are available on the school system’s website.

Meal prices for the 2025-2026 school year are:

- Elementary school breakfast is \$1.45 and lunch is \$2.90
- Breakfast for secondary level students is \$1.60 and lunch is \$3.15. Milk remains \$0.75 centers.

The school system uses a cafeteria prepayment system through MySchoolBucks.

As of 2024, Charles public schools no longer use Meals Payment Plus for prepayment.

Students may be eligible for free or reduced meals. Eligibility is determined by guidelines developed by the U.S. Department of Agriculture. The application is available online and will be provided to students the first week of school.